

FATHER TO SON

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MAIN POINTS:

- The father is unhappy because there is lack of understanding between them owing to communication gap.
- He is surprised at the fact that he knows nothing about his son though he has lived with him since birth.
- He tries to assess the cause of their differences and refers to the past times to know at what point this gap cropped up. He longs to rebuild their relationship from that point.
- The father thinks that his son is like a seed which he had sown on the land which was not his.
- Now that the plant (son) has grown up, there is no sign of understanding between them.
- The son has grown up just as the father had planned. Yet the father cannot share what the child loves.
- Father is unhappy that his son is trying to carve his own life, creating a world of his own.
- Father thinks that he would forgive his son for his mistakes if he would come back just like the prodigal son in the Bible.
- The father and son have no option but to live in the same world at the same time.
- Both want that the other should take initiative to solve the differences so that they can forgive his mistakes.

Question 1: Do you think that the problem highlighted in the poem is exclusive to the poet or is it universal?

Answer: The poem is written in an autobiographical style. It

describes the relationship between a father and his son. Beginning on an exclusively personal experience, the poem rises to a fairly universal phenomenon—the growing gap and lack of communication amongst the older and younger generations.

Question 2: How is the father's helplessness brought out in the poem?

Answer: The father's helplessness is clearly brought about by the difference of opinion and perception of the father and the son. Usually, a father is the best friend and advisor of his son. However, there is no bond or relationship between the two. It seems that the two are not on speaking terms even while living under the same roof. The father feels helpless that he can't share what his son loves.

Question 3: Identify the phrases and lines that indicate distance between father and son.

Answer: The phrases/lines indicating distance between father and son are:

"I don't understand this child."

"I know nothing of him"

"we speak like strangers, there's no sign (write in one line)
Of understanding in the air."

"What he loves I cannot share."

"Silence surrounds us."

".....see him make and move his world."

Question 4: What is the rhyme scheme of the poem? Is it consistent?

Answer: The poem does not have a consistent rhyme scheme. The first two stanzas have the rhyme- scheme ab ba ba whereas the third and fourth have a slight alteration. The third stanza has abc aba whereas the fourth one has abbcba scheme.

Question 5: What do you think is responsible for the distance between father and son?

Answer: The lack of understanding on the part of the older generation (here, father) is the root of the problem. The father wants the young man to stick to home turf. The son, now a young man, seeks fresh avenues and lives in a world of his own. The father finds it hard to adjust to the growing changes.

Question 6: How can you infer that the father wishes his son to remain at home with him?

Answer: The father finds the son's interests quite different. He is home bound, whereas the son is on the look out for fresh avenues. He aspires for a world of his own. The father wants him to return home even if he undergoes losses by his extravagant ventures. He is willing to make up with him if he agrees to live with him.